FRAILTY



Frailty is a clinical state of increased vulnerability due to age-associated decline in physiological reserve, resulting in compromised ability to cope with external everyday or acute stressors. [1]

Preoperative frailty is associated with increased postoperative complications, mortality, and longer-term negative outcomes, including falls, lower quality of life, non-home discharge, and prolonged length of stay. [2,3]

Screening Tools

The FRAIL Scale is a validated preoperative screening tool for frailty and predictor of mortality and postoperative complications that can be completed entirely by the patient, making it well suited for standardized preoperative screening. [4] Many geriatricians find assessment of ADLs and IADLs to be a useful adjunct.

Although the Clinical Frailty Scale (CFS) is the preferred tool for clinical frailty assessment, it requires clinician judgment and is therefore not appropriate for patient-completed screening. Patients identified as at risk using the FRAIL Scale should undergo further clinical assessment, with the CFS used where appropriate to confirm frailty and inform perioperative planning. [5–7]

FRAIL Scale

Fatigue: Have you felt fatigued all or most of the time in the last month?

Resistance: Cannot walk up one flight of stairs?

Aerobic: Cannot walk one block?

Illnesses: Do you have more than 5 illnesses?

Loss of weight: Have you lost more than 5% of your weight in the last 6 months?

SCORING Add 1 for every **YES** ≥3 = frail | 1 or 2 = prefrail

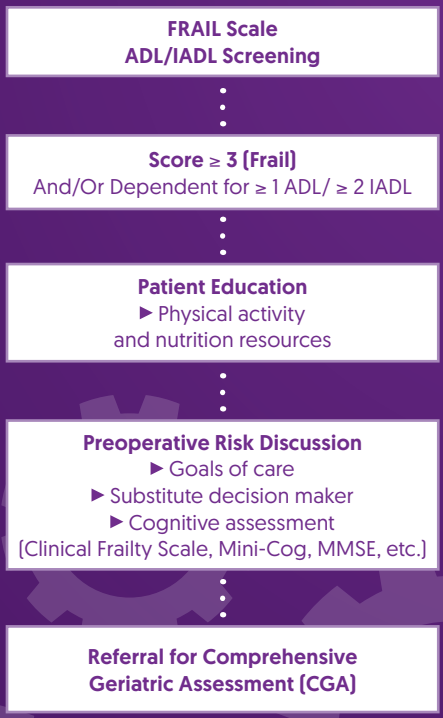
From Morley JE, Vellas B, Abellan van Kan G, et al. J Am Med Dir Assoc 2013;14:392-397.

Frailty Screening Questions

ADLS (Activity of Daily Living) FLAG IF ANSWER "WITH HELP" TO 1 OR MORE	
Do you take a bath	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you dress yourself	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you eat your meals	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you walk	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you use the toilet	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you brush your teeth and hair	☐ On your own ☐ with help?

IADLS (Instrumental Activity of Daily Living) FLAG IF ANSWER "WITH HELP" TO 2 OR MORE	
Do you shop for essentials such as groceries	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you do the daily housekeeping such as dishes and laundry	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you manage your personal finances, such as bills and taxes	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you prepare daily meals	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Do you drive, use public transport, or use taxis	☐ On your own ☐ with help?
Have you fallen in the past year?	☐ Yes ☐ No

FRAILTY ALGORITHM



Prehabilitation and Optimization Recommendations

Patient Education	⚙ Refer to online patient resources for frailty-specific physical prehab and nutrition resources, including information on how to access physiotherapy for patients with frailty
Preoperative Risk Discussion	⚙ Assess goals of care and advance care plan (e.g., complete MOST form) ⚙ Identify substitute decision maker ⚙ Assess for cognitive impairment and ability to provide consent for surgery ⚙ Refer to online provider resources for assessment tools (Clinical Frailty Scale, Mini-Cog, MMSE, etc.)
Referral for Comprehensive Geriatric Assessment (CGA)	⚙ Referral to geriatrician can be useful prior to moderate/highly invasive surgery ⚙ If no local specialist, refer to online provider resources for telehealth consultation options